

The Ransom of Red Chief

O. Henry · 1907

First published: Saturday Evening Post, Jul 1907

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_ransom_of_Red_Chief_and_other_O._Henry_stories_for_boys/The_Ransom_Of_Red_Chief (revision 13357856), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (accessible text, well suited to the scaffolded-support track; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about comic reversal?
- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about greed?
- What does The Ransom of Red Chief suggest about childhood?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Ransom of Red Chief	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*comic reversal* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Ransom of Red Chief

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about O. Henry's life or times connects to comic reversal in “The Ransom of Red Chief”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (comic reversal, greed, childhood).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a sleepy Alabama town around 1900. O. Henry lived in the South and knew small-town con men; kidnapping for ransom was a feared crime in the period.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Saturday Evening Post on 6 July 1907; collected in Whirligigs (1910).

Then: Very popular and adapted into film several times.

Now: A comic classic for teaching verbal and situational irony and humorous first-person narration.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Two small-time crooks, Sam and Bill, kidnap the young son of a wealthy man and demand a $2,000 ransom.

Main themes

- irony and reversal.
- greed.
- comic chaos.

Why it matters

It shows how humor works through reversal and voice.

Spoilers · teacher only

The boy, who calls himself Red Chief, torments them so much that they end up paying the father $250 to take him back.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Ransom of Red Chief: Describe a plan that went hilariously wrong.
Prompt: Before we open The Ransom of Red Chief: Describe a plan that went hilariously wrong.

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
situational irony; verbal irony; hyperbole; diction; first-person narrator.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. O. Henry was the pen name of William Sydney Porter, born on 11 September 1862 in Greensboro, North Carolina. He trained as a pharmacist, moved to Texas, and worked as a draftsman, bank teller and humorous journalist. Convicted of embezzling from the Austin bank where he had worked (he maintained his innocence), he served about three years in the Ohio Penitentiary (1898–1901), where he began publishing stories as O. Henry. In New York he wrote a story a week for the New York World and produced hundreds of tales of ordinary city people, famous for their warmth, wordplay and twist endings. He died in New York on 5 June 1910. The world of the book. Set in a sleepy Alabama town around 1900. O. Henry lived in the South and knew small-town con men; kidnapping for ransom was a feared crime in the period. Publication and reception. First published in The Saturday Evening Post on 6 July 1907; collected in Whirligigs (1910). Then: Very popular and adapted into film several times. Now: A comic classic for teaching verbal and situational irony and humorous first-person narration.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" slowly and put it in my own words: Sam says the kidnapping looked like a good thing, but asks us to wait till he tells the story. Next, craft. I notice the casual, spoken voice and the sly "looked like," which signals that appearances fooled him. The strongest word is "looked": it separates how the plan seemed from how it turned out, which is the whole joke. Then, effect. Why does O. Henry open with a narrator admitting the plan only "looked like" a good thing? My answer: The kidnappers will end up paying the father to take the boy back; O. Henry tells us from the first line that this is a story of a plan collapsing on its makers.

> *It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you* (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" slowly and put it in my own words: Sam says the kidnapping looked like a good thing, but asks us to wait till he tells the story. Next, craft. I notice the casual, spoken voice and the sly "looked like," which signals that appearances fooled him. The strongest word is "looked": it separates how the plan seemed from how it turned out, which is the whole joke. Then, effect. Why does O. Henry open with a narrator admitting the plan only "looked like" a good thing? My answer: The kidnappers will end up paying the father to take the boy back; O. Henry tells us from the first line that this is a story of a plan collapsing on its makers.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Two small-time crooks, Sam and Bill, kidnap the young son of a wealthy man and demand a $2,000 ransom. Themes to track: irony and reversal.: greed.: comic chaos.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: comic reversal. Prediction: Sam and Bill's plan to kidnap a banker's son in Summit, Alabama, will not go the way kidnappers expect. Question: who will end up paying whom?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Ransom of Red Chief: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: comic reversal. Prediction: Sam and Bill's plan to kidnap a banker's son in Summit, Alabama, will not go the way kidnappers expect. Question: who will end up paying whom?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Ransom of Red Chief still matter? It shows how humor works through reversal and voice.
Anchor question: Why might The Ransom of Red Chief still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows how humor works through reversal and voice.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
O. Henry worked in Texas and Alabama before moving to New York, and he loved humor and wordplay. How might this background shape a story about two con men in Alabama? Answer: Accept answers such as: he knew small Southern towns; he loved playing with big words; his twist endings.
Exit ticket: O. Henry worked in Texas and Alabama before moving to New York, and he loved humor and wordplay. How might this background shape a story about two con men in Alabama?
Answer: Accept answers such as: he knew small Southern towns; he loved playing with big words; his twist endings.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Ransom of Red Chief.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "O. Henry" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/O-Henry); NCpedia, "Porter, William Sydney (O. Henry)" (https://www.ncpedia.org/biography/porter-william-sydney); O. Henry Museum (Austin) (https://www.austintexas.gov/department/o-henry-museum)

Lesson 2: The Ransom of Red Chief

Focus: a crime that backfires

Objective: Students will analyze how irony develops in “The Ransom of Red Chief” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (kidnapping played for comedy, dated stereotypes in a child playing "indian", racial slurs (period terms)): Sensitive content: Kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian"; racial slurs (period terms). Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian"; racial slurs (period terms).
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers pay and flee.

Background: Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang.

Significance: A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to irony and reversal because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes kidnapping played for comedy; dated stereotypes in a child playing "Indian"; racial slurs (period terms).
Prompt: Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to irony and reversal because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: power shifts entirely to the child.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: dictating — issue commands or orders for; egotism — too much concern with oneself; humiliating — shameful; making one feel ashamed; impudent — marked by casual disrespect; vicinity — a surrounding or nearby region. “egotism”: Origin: possibly Latin ego (“I”). “humiliating”: Origin of “humiliate”: Late Latin humiliātus; earlier Latin humilis (“lowly”). “impudent”: Origin: Latin impudēns (“shameless”). “vicinity”: Origin: Latin vīcīnitās (“neighborhood”).
Words: dictating: issue commands or orders for · egotism: too much concern with oneself · humiliating: shameful; making one feel ashamed · impudent: marked by casual disrespect · vicinity: a surrounding or nearby region

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang. A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary. Irony: The kidnappers pay the ransom. Diction / vocabulary: Sam's pompous vocabulary is comically inappropriate. Hyperbole: Bill's sufferings are exaggerated for laughter. Watch for the ransom letter: the plan's pomposity, signed "Two Desperate Men."

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” slowly and put it in my own words: Sam, the narrator, says the kidnapping looked like a good idea, but we should wait until he tells us what happened. Next, craft. I notice the colon and the conversational "but wait till I tell you," as if he is leaning in to tell a joke on himself. The strongest word is “wait”: the word promises that the "good thing" will go wrong, so the suspense becomes comic. Then, effect. What does the narrator's warning tell us before the story begins? My answer: Before the story begins, the narrator's warning tells us the kidnapping scheme failed; the fun of the story will be watching two crooks get beaten by the boy they kidnapped.

> *It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you* (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1)

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” slowly and put it in my own words: Sam, the narrator, says the kidnapping looked like a good idea, but we should wait until he tells us what happened. Next, craft. I notice the colon and the conversational "but wait till I tell you," as if he is leaning in to tell a joke on himself. The strongest word is “wait”: the word promises that the "good thing" will go wrong, so the suspense becomes comic. Then, effect. What does the narrator's warning tell us before the story begins? My answer: Before the story begins, the narrator's warning tells us the kidnapping scheme failed; the fun of the story will be watching two crooks get beaten by the boy they kidnapped.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: "Desperate" is meant to sound dangerous, but by the end it means desperate to get rid of the boy. Ask: How does this line connect to irony and reversal? Expected: Power shifts entirely to the child. (The signature.)

> *Two Desperate Men (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: "Desperate" is meant to sound dangerous, but by the end it means desperate to get rid of the boy.
Ask: How does this line connect to irony and reversal?
Expected answer: Power shifts entirely to the child. (The signature.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for irony, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a crime that backfires? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Ransom of Red Chief develops the idea of a crime that backfires. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. When the text says “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1), it shows this directly. Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset’s hand."
Task: Annotate the story for irony, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a crime that backfires? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Ransom of Red Chief develops the idea of a crime that backfires. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. When the text says “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1), it shows this directly. Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset’s hand."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended? Ask: is Mr. Dorset a better con man than Sam?
Anchor question: Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?
Facilitation: Ask: is Mr. Dorset a better con man than Sam?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a crime that backfires? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. ("It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you", The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a crime that backfires? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. ("It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you", The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes a crime that backfires. Key takeaway: power shifts entirely to the child.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** The kidnappers pay the ransom.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Sam's pompous vocabulary is comically inappropriate.
- **Hyperbole:** Bill's sufferings are exaggerated for laughter.

Themes and how they develop

- **irony and reversal:** power shifts entirely to the child.

Symbols and motifs

- **the ransom letter:** the plan's pomposity, signed "Two Desperate Men."

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1) Foreshadowing.
- "Two Desperate Men" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56) The signature.
- "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95) The reversal.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits.
Evidence: "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you" (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1)

Reasoning: Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
dictating (verb)	issue commands or orders for	*Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.*	
egotism (noun)	too much concern with oneself	*I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance fail.*	"egotism": Origin: possibly Latin ego ("I"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/egotism#Etymology)
humiliating (adjective)	shameful; making one feel ashamed	*They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or caterpillars.*	"humiliating": Origin of "humiliate": Late Latin humiliātus; earlier Latin humilis ("lowly"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/humiliate#Etymology)
impudent (adjective)	marked by casual disrespect	*"Great pirates of Penzance!" says I; "of all the impudent——"*	"impudent": Origin: Latin impudēns ("shameless"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/impudent#Etymology)
vicinity (noun)	a surrounding or nearby region	*I went up on the peak of the little mountain and ran my eye over the contiguous vicinity.*	"vicinity": Origin: Latin vīcīnitās ("neighborhood"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/vicinity#Etymology)
accidents (noun)	an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury	*"No," says Bill, "nothing chronic except malaria and accidents.*	
awakened (verb)	stirred up	*Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill.*	"awakened": Origin of "awaken": Old English awæcnan. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/awaken#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with comic reversal?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: To collect a ransom
2. What does the boy call himself? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Red Chief
3. How does the boy feel about being kidnapped? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: He enjoys it as an adventure
4. What does the father propose? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back
5. Who suffers most from the boy's games? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Bill
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Ransom of Red Chief" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers pay and flee.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Ransom of Red Chief"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Ransom of Red Chief" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid." What does "dictating" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: dictating: issue commands or orders for.
10. Reread: "I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance fail." What does "egotism" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: egotism: too much concern with oneself.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Ransom of Red Chief" suggest about a crime that backfires? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary.

2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about a crime that backfires? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill.”, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Ransom of Red Chief”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Two con men, Sam (the narrator) and Bill, kidnap the son of a prominent man in Summit, Alabama, for a $2,000 ransom. The boy, calling himself Red Chief, loves the adventure and torments Bill. The father, Ebenezer Dorset, counter-offers: he will take the boy back if they pay him $250. The kidnappers…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Ransom of Red Chief” set up that the rest of The Ransom of Red Chief will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever had a plan go completely the opposite of what you intended?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with comic reversal? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. On diction / vocabulary: Sam's pompous vocabulary is comically

inappropriate. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Background: Published in 1907 in the Saturday Evening Post. O. Henry had served prison time for embezzlement and knew con-men slang. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A model of situational irony and of comic narration through an inflated vocabulary.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Ransom of Red Chief” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a crime that backfires? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Ransom of Red Chief”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to greed: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. On irony: The kidnappers pay the ransom. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Ransom of Red Chief” treats a crime that backfires with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Ransom of Red Chief see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve comic reversal? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1): Foreshadowing. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a crime that backfires? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56): The signature. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Useful evidence: “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95): The reversal. Theme link: power shifts entirely to the

child. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does the boy feel about being kidnapped?
   A. He enjoys it as an adventure
   B. He tries to escape
   C. He is terrified
   D. He is bored

   Key: A (He enjoys it as an adventure)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “"No," says Bill, "nothing chronic except malaria and _____.” Word bank: accidents, humiliating, dictating, egotism

   Key: accidents
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the father propose?
   A. He calls the sheriff
   B. He refuses to answer
   C. The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back
   D. He pays double

   Key: C (The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who suffers most from the boy's games?
   A. The father
   B. Bill
   C. The sheriff
   D. Sam

   Key: B (Bill)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1: “It _____ like a good thing: but wait till I tell you”

   Key: looked
6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the boy call himself?
   A. Chief Dorset
   B. Red Chief
   C. Black Scout
   D. Old Hank

   Key: B (Red Chief)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy?

   A. Because he is lost

   B. To get revenge on his father

   C. To teach him a lesson

   D. To collect a ransom

   Key: D (To collect a ransom)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Iwent up on the peak of the little mountain and ran my eye over the contiguous _____.” Word bank: vicinity, egotism, dictating, humiliating

   Key: vicinity

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95: “Bill was _____ out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand”

   Key: counting

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Just at daybreak I was _____ by a series of awful screams from Bill.” Word bank: humiliating, dictating, egotism, awakened

    Key: awakened

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Foreshadowing.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Ransom of Red Chief”?

    A. A choice the reader must make

    B. Courage and guilt in a small community

    C. A story told to protect a livelihood

    D. A crime that backfires

    Key: D (A crime that backfires)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The signature.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Ransom of Red Chief”? Sam's pompous vocabulary is comically inappropriate.

    A. Irony

    B. Symbolism

    C. Diction / vocabulary

    D. Alliteration

    Key: C (Diction / vocabulary)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1).

    Sample answer: Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset’s hand."

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The signature.
17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Ransom of Red Chief”? The kidnappers pay the ransom.
    A. Point of view
    B. Foreshadowing
    C. Plot
    D. Irony

    Key: D (Irony)
18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The reversal.
19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand."
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Foreshadowing.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how irony and reversal develops from an earlier story to “The Ransom of Red Chief”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: power shifts entirely to the child.
22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “"Great pirates of Penzance!" says I; "of all the impudent——"”, what does “impudent” most nearly mean?
    A. too much concern with oneself
    B. marked by casual disrespect
    C. shameful; making one feel ashamed
    D. issue commands or orders for

    Key: B (marked by casual disrespect)
23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance fail.”, what does “egotism” most nearly mean?
    A. too much concern with oneself
    B. shameful; making one feel ashamed
    C. marked by casual disrespect
    D. issue commands or orders for

    Key: A (too much concern with oneself)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.", what does "dictating" most nearly mean?

    A. marked by casual disrespect

    B. issue commands or orders for

    C. shameful; making one feel ashamed

    D. too much concern with oneself

    Key: B (issue commands or orders for)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 9, 4, 8, 1, 10, 3, 7, 2, 12, 11, 13, 17, 18, 14, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	3, 9, 4, 1, 10, 8, 2, 5, 12, 11, 13, 14, 15, 17, 20, 19	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	1, 3, 9, 4, 2, 10, 5, 13, 11, 12, 17, 15, 18, 14, 20, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 3, 10, 7, 8, 1, 12, 13, 11, 18, 15, 14, 17, 19, 21, 20	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	8, 10, 22, 23, 7, 13, 12, 11, 14, 18, 15, 17, 19, 16, 21, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	8, 3, 9, 24, 23, 13, 12, 11, 15, 18, 17, 14, 20, 19, 21, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	8, 2, 4, 22, 3, 13, 11, 12, 17, 18, 14, 15, 19, 16, 20, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	8, 5, 24, 3, 4, 11, 13, 12, 17, 15, 14, 18, 20, 19, 21, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	2, 7, 5, 22, 4, 11, 12, 13, 18, 15, 17, 14, 21, 20, 19, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	2, 24, 10, 6, 8, 13, 11, 12, 17, 14, 15, 18, 19, 16, 21, 20	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Ransom of Red Chief," how does Henry show a crime that backfires? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): In The Ransom of Red Chief, how does Henry develop the idea of a crime that backfires? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Ransom of Red Chief develops the idea of a crime that backfires. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of a crime that backfires. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Ransom of Red Chief suggests about a crime that backfires. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses irony in The Ransom of Red Chief to complicate the reader's understanding of a crime that backfires. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Ransom of Red Chief within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a crime that backfires responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Ransom of Red Chief alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a crime that backfires follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Ransom of Red Chief and its treatment of a crime that backfires. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Ransom of Red Chief as evidence for a larger claim about a crime that backfires in The Ransom of Red Chief. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Ransom of Red Chief as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a crime that backfires. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Ransom of Red Chief.

SAT-style questions

1. *They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or caterpillars.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “humiliating” most nearly mean?

   A. shameful; making one feel ashamed

   B. stirred up

   C. a surrounding or nearby region

   D. an unfortunate mishap; especially one causing damage or injury

2. *Just at daybreak I was awakened by a series of awful screams from Bill. They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or caterpillars. It's an awful thing to hear a strong, desperate, fat man scream incontinently in a cave at daybreak.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Ransom of Red Chief"?

A. The art of the deadpan tall tale

B. A crime that backfires

C. Wishes that defy fate

D. A story told to protect a livelihood

SAT key: 1. A (shameful; making one feel ashamed); 2. B (A crime that backfires)

Unit test

The Ransom of Red Chief: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does the boy feel about being kidnapped?
   A. He enjoys it as an adventure
   B. He tries to escape
   C. He is terrified
   D. He is bored

   Key: A (He enjoys it as an adventure)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1: “It _____ like a good thing: but wait till I tell you”
   Key: looked
3. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Iwent up on the peak of the little mountain and ran my eye over the contiguous _____.” Word bank: vicinity, egotism, dictating, humiliating
   Key: vicinity
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why do Sam and Bill kidnap the boy?
   A. Because he is lost
   B. To get revenge on his father
   C. To teach him a lesson
   D. To collect a ransom

   Key: D (To collect a ransom)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Just at daybreak I was _____ by a series of awful screams from Bill.” Word bank: humiliating, dictating, egotism, awakened
   Key: awakened
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95: “Bill was _____ out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand”
   Key: counting
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the boy call himself?
   A. Chief Dorset
   B. Red Chief

C. Black Scout

D. Old Hank

Key: B (Red Chief)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who suffers most from the boy's games?

   A. The father

   B. Bill

   C. The sheriff

   D. Sam

   Key: B (Bill)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “"No," says Bill, "nothing chronic except malaria and _____.” Word bank: accidents, humiliating, dictating, egotism

   Key: accidents

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does the father propose?

    A. He calls the sheriff

    B. He refuses to answer

    C. The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back

    D. He pays double

    Key: C (The kidnappers pay him to take the boy back)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Foreshadowing.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Ransom of Red Chief”?

    A. A choice the reader must make

    B. Courage and guilt in a small community

    C. A story told to protect a livelihood

    D. A crime that backfires

    Key: D (A crime that backfires)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The signature.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Ransom of Red Chief”? The kidnappers pay the ransom.

    A. Point of view

    B. Foreshadowing

    C. Plot

    D. Irony

    Key: D (Irony)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Ransom of Red Chief”? Sam's pompous vocabulary is comically inappropriate.

    A. Irony

B. Symbolism

C. Diction / vocabulary

D. Alliteration

Key: C (Diction / vocabulary)

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset's hand” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 95). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The reversal.
17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1).
    Sample answer: Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset’s hand."
18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how irony and reversal develops from an earlier story to “The Ransom of Red Chief”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: power shifts entirely to the child.
19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The kidnappers' plan backfires so completely that the victim's father profits.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Sam warns "It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you," and at the end "Bill was counting out two hundred and fifty dollars into Dorset’s hand."
20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “It looked like a good thing: but wait till I tell you” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 1) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Foreshadowing.
21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Two Desperate Men” (The Ransom of Red Chief, paragraph 56) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The signature.
22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “"Great pirates of Penzance!" says I; "of all the impudent——"”, what does “impudent” most nearly mean?

    A. too much concern with oneself

    B. marked by casual disrespect

    C. shameful; making one feel ashamed

    D. issue commands or orders for

    Key: B (marked by casual disrespect)
23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “They weren't yells, or howls, or shouts, or whoops, or yawps, such as you'd expect from a manly set of vocal organs—they were simply indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams, such as women emit when they see ghosts or…”, what does “humiliating” most nearly mean?

    A. shameful; making one feel ashamed

    B. issue commands or orders for

    C. marked by casual disrespect

    D. too much concern with oneself

Key: A (shameful; making one feel ashamed)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "I'm a grown person with masculine proclivities and habits of self-defense, but there is a time when all systems of egotism and predominance fail.", what does "egotism" most nearly mean?

    A. too much concern with oneself

    B. shameful; making one feel ashamed

    C. marked by casual disrespect

    D. issue commands or orders for

    Key: A (too much concern with oneself)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "Also, I thought it best to send a peremptory letter to old man Dorset that day, demanding the ransom and dictating how it should be paid.", what does "dictating" most nearly mean?

    A. marked by casual disrespect

    B. issue commands or orders for

    C. shameful; making one feel ashamed

    D. too much concern with oneself

    Key: B (issue commands or orders for)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 2, 10, 3, 8, 5, 4, 7, 9, 6, 11, 12, 13, 15, 17, 14, 16, 19	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 10, 9, 4, 3, 8, 5, 2, 6, 7, 13, 12, 11, 17, 16, 15, 20, 21	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	5, 3, 7, 1, 10, 9, 6, 8, 4, 12, 13, 11, 14, 17, 16, 15, 19, 18	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	1, 6, 10, 5, 2, 7, 3, 8, 13, 12, 11, 14, 16, 15, 17, 19, 18, 21	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	3, 10, 22, 23, 9, 24, 1, 11, 13, 12, 17, 15, 14, 16, 18, 19, 20, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	7, 6, 4, 3, 8, 1, 24, 13, 11, 12, 16, 15, 17, 14, 21, 19, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	7, 25, 8, 10, 5, 2, 23, 13, 12, 11, 14, 17, 15, 16, 21, 20, 19, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	1, 6, 23, 3, 4, 7, 10, 11, 13, 12, 15, 17, 16, 14, 19, 20, 18, 21	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	7, 22, 10, 23, 2, 4, 5, 13, 11, 12, 17, 14, 15, 16, 18, 20, 21, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	23, 22, 25, 2, 6, 5, 9, 11, 13, 12, 16, 17, 14, 15, 21, 19, 20, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Ransom of Red Chief: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how O. Henry develops comic reversal across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Ransom of Red Chief and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to greed.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Ransom of Red Chief finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of childhood. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Comic reversal

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about comic reversal. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops comic reversal across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of comic reversal. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of comic reversal, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of comic reversal in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on comic reversal in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Greed

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about greed. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops greed across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of greed. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of greed, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of greed in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about greed in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on greed in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Childhood

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Ransom of Red Chief teaches about childhood. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops childhood across The Ransom of Red Chief. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Ransom of Red Chief (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of childhood. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Ransom of Red Chief (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of childhood, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Ransom of Red Chief's treatment of childhood in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on childhood in The Ransom of Red Chief, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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